



Report Date: March 20, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

[Submit comments to the Board](#)

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Business Services
SUBJECT: Designated Smoking Area at Select Special Events in Summer 2026 – Pilot Program

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve, as a pilot program, the requirements of the Park Board Smoking Regulation Bylaw not be strictly enforced in relation to the 2026 Great Outdoor Comedy Festival and the 2026 Rosé Disco and Country Club events to allow for the establishment of designated smoking areas at these events; and
- B. THAT Park Board staff will report back to the Board regarding the efficacy of this pilot project no later than March 31, 2027.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

The Vancouver Park Board introduced a no smoking policy in parks and beaches in July 2010 to promote a healthy urban environment and support active living and wellness. While policy compliance is generally positive amongst most day-to-day park users, illicit smoking continues to be an issue of concern at large events and gatherings. Designated smoking areas have shown to be effective in significantly reducing illicit smoking at events and are now being introduced by many cities to remedy this issue.

The purpose of this report is to present the concept of designated smoking areas at events to the Park Board, review requests from two event organizers (Triostar Productions and Feaster Festivals & Events) to implement this approach (tobacco and vaping products only) at their events in Summer 2026 on a pilot program basis, and seek the Board's approval for this request.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

Per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over parkland use in the City of Vancouver (including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements within parks) and approves the use of all lands under its jurisdiction on such terms as the Park Board may decide.

On June 22, 2010, the Board approved the Park Board Smoking Regulation Bylaw to regulate smoking in parks and also approved the Ticket Offences Bylaws to permit enforcement of Park bylaws by way of municipal tickets.

Per the Parks Control Bylaws, Park Board approval is required for divergences or exemptions to these Bylaws.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Parks Control Bylaw and No-Smoking Policy

The Vancouver Park Board is responsible for stewarding more than 240 parks and nearly 18 kilometers of beaches in the city. These open spaces are used by millions of people and offer residents and visitors of all ages valuable opportunities for recreation and relaxation.

The Vancouver Parks Control Bylaw (Bylaw No. 5655) outlines the rules, regulations, and restrictions governing all public parks and beaches managed by the Park Board. It dictates the parameters of public use to maintain order, safety, and cleanliness.

Following the introduction of restrictions on smoking in outdoor public spaces in numerous jurisdictions across North America, and aligned to the Park Board's commitment to promote a healthy urban environment and support for active living and wellness, a no smoking policy was approved by the Park Board on July 5, 2010. This new regulation applies to all parks, including pathways, playgrounds, playing surfaces contained within each, as well as all city beaches.

Special Events

Civic open spaces such as parks, plazas, and beaches, as well as admission-based facilities including VanDusen Botanical Garden and Bloedel Conservatory, are popular sites for entertainment and celebrations of all natures and sizes. The Park Board's role in supporting special events is primarily that of a host, issuing over 1,500 permits annually for special events and other activities across its open space network and facilities; the Park Board also organizes several events for the benefit and enjoyment of Vancouverites and visitors to the city.

Special events play an essential role in building community connection, fostering diversity and cohesion, driving economic activity through tourism and support for local businesses, promoting arts, sports and culture, and providing opportunities for education, awareness and civic engagement.

Accordingly, Park Board staff work collaboratively with event organizers to enable events, improve the efficiency of operations, and minimize/reduce potential risks.

What is the Issue?

While significant effort is taken to prevent illegal smoking at events, illicit smoking is frequent at large public gatherings, especially music festivals and outdoor concerts. Surveys indicate that up to 37% of festival-goers smoke – roughly double the rate of the general public – leading to widespread, routine rule-breaking at non-smoking events.

Illegal smoking at events usually happens due to limited security resources, crowd density making it easy for attendees to hide their actions, the discreet nature of vapes, and municipal bylaw reliance on voluntary compliance rather than active enforcement/ticketing. Because event staff cannot monitor every person, attendees often exploit these gaps to circumvent smoking bans.

Common ways illegal smoking happens at events includes:

- Secluded & dark areas – People migrate to poorly lit zones, backstage corridors, or dense, hidden areas where security visibility is minimal;
- Restroom stalls – Bathrooms remain a primary location for breaking smoking rules, as attendees can lock themselves in a stall to consume cigarettes and other products;

- Security distraction – When crowds are immense, security staff prioritize public safety incidents and medical emergencies over smoking enforcement;
- Vape concealment – Attendees also use highly discreet, odorless, or low-vapor e-cigarettes that look like everyday items or hide them in their sleeves to exhale smoke directly into their clothing; and
- "Spotter" system – In large crowds or during high-energy performances, friends notify or block the view of nearby security or event staff.

DISCUSSION

Proposal

In order to reduce illicit smoking at their events, reduce public safety risks and enhance park protection, two event producers – Trixstar Productions and Feaster Festivals & Events – are seeking Board approval for an exemption to the Park Board's Smoking Regulation Bylaw in order to offer designated smoking areas (tobacco and vaping products only), on a pilot program basis, for their Summer 2026 events. Specifically,

- **Great Outdoors Comedy Festival (Trixstar Productions)**
 - **Description:** Great Outdoors Comedy Festival is a three-day comedy festival entering its fourth season in Vancouver. The Festival has been professionally and successfully delivered annually and offers an inclusive and safe experience that celebrates and features all forms of performance comedy, from local talent to star attractions.
 - **Location:** Brockton Fields in Stanley Park
 - **Date:** August 28 to 30, 2026
- **Country Club Festival (Feaster Festivals & Events)**
 - **Description:** Country Club Festival is an outdoor country themed event featuring live performances from Canadian and emerging country artists, alongside curated beverage offerings, food vendors, and interactive country themed activities. The event creates a lively, social atmosphere and offers a unique cultural experience within Vancouver's summer festival calendar, celebrating country music, western culture, and community gathering.
 - **Location:** Jericho Beach Park
 - **Date:** July 25, 2026
- **Rosé Disco Festival (Feaster Festivals & Events)**
 - **Description:** Rosé Disco is a daytime music and wine festival designed to support British Columbia's local wine industry while delivering an inclusive and accessible cultural experience for the community. The event provides local producers with a meaningful platform to connect with new audiences through responsible, educational, and engaging programming. Rosé Disco features well-established Canadian artists, affordable ticket pricing, daytime scheduling, and thoughtful site planning to encourage broad participation across diverse communities.
 - **Location:** Jericho Beach Park
 - **Date:** July 26, 2026

The latter two events are being hosted at Park Board locations after being displaced from the PNE due to the FIFA Fan Festival activation. These events are proceeding under the authority delegated to the General Manager of the Park Board, which was approved by the Board at a public meeting on February 2, 2026, for events impacted by FIFA World Cup 2026. More information related to these two initiatives will be provided in a separate memo as requested by the Board.

Subject to Park Board approval, the abovementioned organizers will work with Park Board staff to determine the size, location, and operations plans for the proposed designated smoking areas within their event areas.

Why is this needed?

Designated smoking areas at events, when effectively managed, signposted, and supported by active security enforcement, help reduce illicit smoking while simultaneously improving public safety and enhancing park protection (particularly during the dry summer months and noting that locally, Metro Vancouver implemented Stage 2 water restrictions on May 1 (skipping Stage 1 altogether) in the anticipation of a hot, dry summer with threat of drought). Event organizers have consistently observed that offering clearly delineated smoking zones decreases illicit smoking throughout the broader venue footprint due to:

- Clear compliance – Smokers prefer having an accessible, authorized place to smoke or vape. Providing convenient designated zones – such as the fenced-in areas successfully used at summer festivals – decreases the likelihood of attendees lighting up illegally at events.
- Safer alternatives – At public events, designated smoking locations naturally encourage attendees to consume in designated areas, lowering the risk of second-hand smoke exposure in densely packed, family-oriented spaces.
- Municipal regulations – In municipalities across Metro Vancouver public spaces are strictly smoke-free. Offering contained, permitted zones prevents attendees from stepping just outside event boundaries to smoke illegally or violate municipal by-laws.

Ultimately, while strict, completely smoke-free rules require rigorous oversight, pairing prohibitions with designated smoking areas – along with proper enforcement and event public health regulations and fines – has been shown to promote significantly better overall compliance.

Considering these proven benefits and results, multiple cities across Canada that restrict smoking in outdoor public spaces have supported the introduction of designated smoking areas for special events in their communities, including Surrey, Kelowna, Edmonton, Calgary, Winnipeg, Mississauga, Toronto, Montreal, and Halifax. Locally, the PNE also permits smoking within designated areas.

Liquor as a Past Precedent for Bylaw Exemptions

In recent years (between May 2021 and May 2024), the Park Board has approved a series of amendments to the Parks Control Bylaw to designate specific locations where liquor may be consumed in parks. Prior to these amendments, however, Park Bylaws explicitly restricted the consumption of liquor in park spaces, unless expressly approved by the Board. As part of the special event approval process, the Park Board regularly approves designated areas for liquor consumption in parks falling outside of these designated areas. The proposed pilot program in this report seeks to follow a similar model whereby designated smoking areas for events would

be expressly approved by the Board, while maintaining the integrity and authority of the existing no smoking policy.

Compliance with Park Board Bylaws

Consistent with all events taking place in Park Board spaces, the event organizer would be responsible for compliance with all other applicable Park Board bylaws.

Event Benefits

Staff consider requests of this nature very carefully and wish to emphasize that advancing this initiative does not represent an endorsement or support for the consumption of tobacco products/validation of the smoking culture. Rather, staff are supportive of pursuing this pilot program due to the anticipated benefits which include:

- Reduced illegal smoking/improved Park Bylaw compliance (either within or adjacent to the event location);
- Improved public safety;
- Improved park protection during the dry summer season;
- Operational efficiencies for event organizers (resources can be focussed rather than dispersed around the event area); and
- Improved guest experience.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

All expenses related to the delivery and execution of a designated smoking areas at the events identified in this report would be borne by the event producers; there will be no cost to the Park Board related to this initiative.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

The proposed pilot program is supported by the Vancouver Police Department, Vancouver Fire Rescue Services, and the City of Vancouver's Public Safety and Risk Management teams due to the potential for improved bylaw compliance as well as the public and risk reduction benefits.

Park Board staff will work with the organizers of these events to collect observations and data related to this initiative to support a report back to the Board no later than March 31, 2027.

Park Board staff acknowledge that advancing this pilot program could present some potential organizational reputational risks and/or be misinterpreted as support for the consumption of tobacco products/validation of the smoking culture. It is believed that these risks/issues can be mitigated through appropriate communications and data sharing.

Lastly, and consistent with current practices, this initiative would be subject to a review and Board report back before designated smoking areas are introduced at these or other events in the future.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

While the Park Board's no smoking policy and public compliance-based approach has proven effective amongst general park users, illicit smoking at large events continues to be an issue of concern. Designated smoking areas at large gatherings in other cities have proven to be effective in significantly reducing illegal smoking at events and are being introduced by other cities to

remedy this issue. Motivated by the opportunity to promote Park Bylaw compliance at events, improve public safety, and enhance park protection, this report contemplates the introduction of designated smoking areas (tobacco and vaping products only), on a pilot program basis, for three events in Summer 2026.

Park Board staff have carefully considered the various aspects of this application and are confident that this initiative can be executed successfully and as intended. Accordingly, staff recommend that the Board approve this application as outlined above.

* * * * *